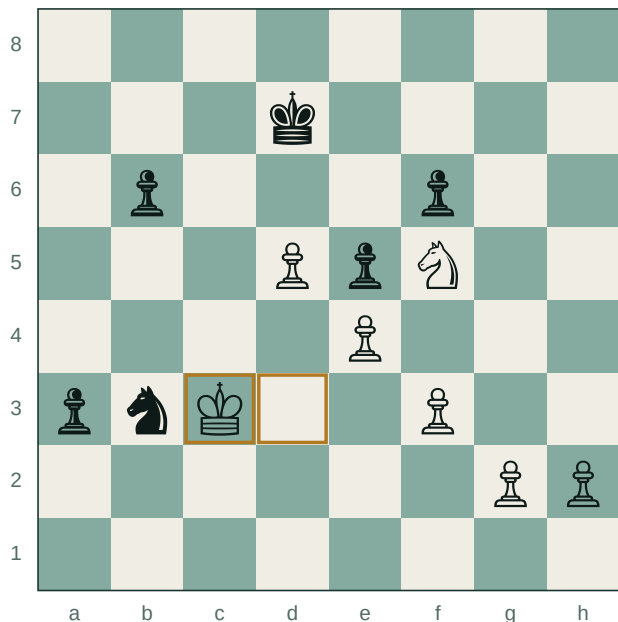


Knight-ending routes: Black, move 39

Knight-ending routes

Black to move



Previous move: 39.Kc3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39...a2 40. Kxb3 a1=Q

39...a2 The pawn moves from a3 to a2. Recorded reply: **40.Kxb3**.

40...a1=Q The pawn moves from a2 to a1. The pawn becomes a queen.

At the end, nominal material is White 8 / Black 12 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +5:** the balance goes from -1 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A knight changes color with every move and may need a detour. Check the route square by square before trusting a race estimate.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Knight endings reward exact route calculation. Forks can change a pawn race, while a distant passer may outrun the knight's short-range movement.

HOW TO LOOK

Map the knight's checking moves and its route to the critical blockade square. Count moves rather than judging distance by appearance.

The defending king is on c3. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.